

Analyst Take: Don't Treat AI Transformation Like an IT Rollout

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Initiatives: Functional Design; Transform HR through AI

Critical perspective and insight from LJ Justice, Director Analyst

Over the last several months, I've spoken with several CHROs who expressed a version of the same frustration: "Every time we bring an AI idea or use case to IT, they shut us down."

I understand the frustration. AI introduces legitimate questions around governance, security, architecture, data access and enterprise risk. But I increasingly think many CHROs are misreading the source of the resistance.

Before becoming an HR analyst, I worked closely with CIOs and technology leaders. This taught me that IT does not enjoy being treated like a pizza shop, where the business places an order ("*One large AI agent, and I'll take that to-go, please!*") and expects technology teams to figure out the rest.

And to be fair to IT, many AI conversations unintentionally create that dynamic.

Let's revisit an all-too-familiar scenario: a CHRO identifies a promising AI capability and wants to move quickly. IT immediately responds with caution, questions or pushback. The CHRO interprets that response as resistance to HR's transformation, innovation or progress. Meanwhile, IT interprets the request as a loosely defined technology initiative without a clearly articulated business problem, operational priority or intended outcome attached to it. This causes both parties to leave the conversation frustrated.

Let me be clear: I do not believe IT functions are fundamentally resisting HR's AI transformation. I think they are resisting poorly defined transformation agendas.

In my experience, the most effective HR leaders are not starting AI conversations with technology requests. They are starting with where work is broken, overloaded, delayed or unnecessarily complex. Before bringing AI requests to IT, HR leaders need to first take the time to diagnose workflows, identify operational friction and define the business problem the function is actually trying to solve. Start by taking the following steps:

1. Map the workflow before evaluating the technology.

Select a specific workflow that is consistently described as frustrating, slow, repetitive or administratively heavy. Document how the work currently gets done, asking and answering:

- Who is involved?
- What systems are being used?
- Where are approvals required?
- Where are employees manually moving information between people or systems?
- Where does work stall or require follow-up?

2. Identify where time and coordination are being lost.

Look for areas where employees or managers are spending significant time:

- Searching for information.
- Scheduling or coordinating work.
- Documenting updates.
- Responding to repetitive requests.
- Manually summarizing information.
- Preparing reports.
- Chasing approvals.
- Reentering information across systems.

3. Quantify the operational impact.

Before making a request to IT, define why the workflow matters for HR. For example, does it:

- Delay decision making?
- Reduce manager capacity?
- Slow customer responsiveness?
- Increase employee frustration or burnout?
- Create inconsistent execution across teams?
- Limit scalability?

4. Determine where AI could realistically improve the workflow.

Resist the temptation to ask whether AI can “do the whole job.” Instead, identify specific points where AI capabilities could realistically:

- Reduce administrative burden.
- Accelerate information retrieval.
- Automate repetitive coordination.
- Improve documentation.
- Streamline communication.
- Summarize large amounts of information.
- Reduce manual workflow management.

5. Bring IT a transformation problem with defined parameters.

Once the workflow, business impact and potential intervention points are clear, involve IT. At this point, the conversation becomes significantly more productive because IT is evaluating:

- A defined operational challenge.
- Measurable business implications.

- Governance requirements.
- Scalability considerations.
- Architectural constraints.
- Security implications.

This approach should help CHROs move from a request that sounds like a pizza order to one that's much stronger and akin to the following:

Example AI Deployment Request From CHROs to IT

"We reviewed the internal HR case management process. Our review found HRBPs are spending significant time responding to repetitive employee questions, manually routing requests to the appropriate teams, searching across policy documents for answers, documenting case notes and following up on unresolved issues across multiple systems. This is slowing response times, creating inconsistent employee experiences and reducing the time HR can spend on more strategic workforce issues. We think an AI agent could help classify incoming requests, draft responses, summarize case history and automate portions of the intake process while escalating higher-risk or judgement-intensive issues to HR staff. Before moving forward, we'd like your help evaluating security considerations associated with introducing AI into employee support workflows."

This type of conversation now positions HR as an active transformation leader rather than a downstream stakeholder asking IT to evaluate disconnected technology requests. The next time you bring an AI initiative forward, start with the work. Sometimes, the fastest way to gain IT's support on AI is not to increase urgency but to increase clarity.

Recommended by the Author

Some documents may not be available as part of your current Gartner subscription.

[Tool: Communication Guide for CHRO & CIO Partnerships](#)

[Tool: AI Maturity Assessment for HR](#)

[Responsible AI at Work: Six Principles for CHROs to Mitigate Risk at Scale](#)

Choose the Best HR Operating Model for an AI-Enabled Enterprise

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